

07 Form Practice

Applied build · Debugging real form issues

Project brief: course registration form

The form must collect full name, email, a ten-digit phone number, a password of at least eight characters, gender through radio buttons, a course through a dropdown, areas of interest through checkboxes, a resume file, acceptance of the terms, and a submit button.

Reference implementation

```
<form action="/register" method="POST" enctype="multipart/form-data">
  <fieldset>
    <legend>Personal Details</legend>

    <label for="name">Full Name</label>
    <input type="text" id="name" name="fullName" required minlength="3">

    <label for="phone">Phone</label>
    <input type="tel" id="phone" name="phone" pattern="[0-9]{10}"
      title="Enter a 10 digit number" required>
  </fieldset>

  <fieldset>
    <legend>Gender</legend>
    <input type="radio" id="m" name="gender" value="male">
    <label for="m">Male</label>
    <input type="radio" id="f" name="gender" value="female">
    <label for="f">Female</label>
  </fieldset>

  <label for="course">Course</label>
  <select id="course" name="course" required>
    <option value="">-- Select --</option>
    <option value="frontend">Frontend</option>
  </select>

  <input type="file" id="cv" name="resume" accept=".pdf">

  <input type="checkbox" id="terms" name="terms" value="accepted" required>
  <label for="terms">I accept the terms</label>

  <button type="submit">Register</button>
</form>
```

Issues that appear in almost every submission

Symptom	Actual cause
The value never reaches the server.	The <code>name</code> attribute is missing and only <code>id</code> has been supplied.
The uploaded file arrives empty.	The form does not set <code>enctype="multipart/form-data"</code> .
The password is visible in the URL.	The form uses <code>method="GET"</code> where <code>POST</code> is required.
Clicking a button reloads the page.	A <code><button></code> defaults to <code>type="submit"</code> ; a non-submitting button needs <code>type="button"</code> .
Several radio buttons can be selected together.	They do not share the same <code>name</code> .
The placeholder option of a dropdown is accepted as an answer.	That option does not have <code>value=""</code> , so <code>required</code> never triggers.
Clicking the label does not focus the field.	The <code>for</code> attribute does not match the <code>id</code> of the input.
Autofill behaves oddly.	Meaningful <code>autocomplete</code> values such as <code>name</code> , <code>email</code> and <code>current-password</code> have not been set.

HOW CHECKBOXES BEHAVE

An unchecked checkbox is not included in the submitted data at all, so the key is absent rather than false. Backends therefore test whether the key exists, or a hidden input with a default value is placed before the checkbox.

Testing checklist before you submit the project

- Fill the form using only the keyboard, moving with the Tab key. Every control must be reachable and the focus outline must remain visible.
- Submit an empty form and confirm that validation messages identify the specific field.
- Inspect the network request and check that each key carries the expected name.
- Click each label and confirm that focus moves to the associated field.

QUICK RECAP

- Missing `name` attributes and a missing `enctype` cause most silent data loss.
- Buttons submit by default, which explains unexpected page reloads.
- `required` on a dropdown works only when the placeholder option has an empty value.